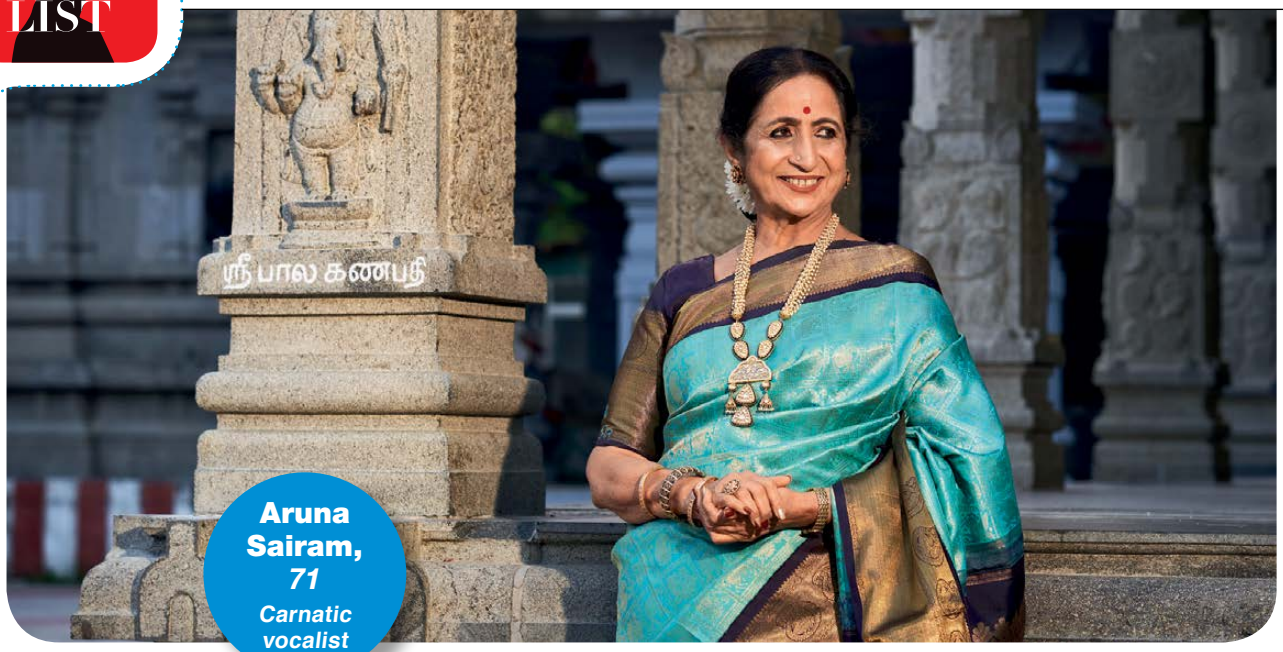


Aruna Sairam, *71*
Carnatic vocalist

AR SUMANTH KUMAR

Sound of Divinity

PICTURE THIS. ARUNA SAIRAM IS REACHING a crescendo of Kalinga Narthana, a composition in which Lord Krishna, as a boy, dances on the head of the serpent Kaliya to stop him from poisoning the Yamuna. Weaving an intricate maze of musical notes and rhythm, she is completely lost in the melody till she is awakened by a standing ovation from the audience.

Dressed in one of her favourite Kanjeevaram silk saris, a string of emeralds around her neck and diamonds glistening in her ears, Aruna looks the picture of the very divinity she sings praises of. It flows from her voice as well, with such searing intensity that it can reduce her mortal audience to tears. So versatile is her range that she can perform Marathi *abhangs* with as much ease as Gospel music.

Aruna inherited music in her genes. Born into a musical family in Mumbai, she was taught music by her mother Rajalakshmi, her lifelong inspiration and ideal. Their home was a refuge for many musicians from the South who came to Mumbai in the late 1960s. They left Aruna with unknown, unheard compositional treasures as gifts. Listening to the various styles of music, including Hindustani, Aruna imbibed the best of the notes. They became the bedrock of her exploration, innovation and evolution of her own style. You could well call it the 'Aruna Sairam Gharana'.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Sairam's versatility unarguably makes her one of the tallest maestros of our times

Yet, it was not enough for Aruna to crack the Chennai concert circuit. "I had no godfather. I had to navigate things myself with an open mind," she says. "The worse would have been if I had to return to Mumbai. But that was not to be. Of course, it took me long to establish myself but, once I settled down, life hit a fast pace."

In January, she curated 'Maargaa 2023', a fundraiser concert in Bengaluru, where artists from different genres and age groups came together to perform. Her concert with French music composer Dominique Vellard and Moroccan Sufi vocalist Noureddine Tahiri in 2011 remains the epitome of prayers for peace. "Music is a universal language. How can music exist without *bhakti*?" asks Aruna, as she recalls her mother singing while lighting the lamp at the temple of her home. ■

–S. Sahaya Ranjit

SORORITY MATTERS

"Women need to be friends with each other and support one another. Take time to build relationships"

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↘ WHAT MAKES HER HAPPY **Singing *'Govinda ala re'* in the rain on the streets of Mumbai; eating chaat at the street corner**